

contribute your favorite resources here

Online courses

- LinkedIn Learning: Advanced Business Development Communication & Negotiation

Books

- Building a Story brand
- Communicating to inspire, align, and activate

Quick reads and videos

- Paul Graham: Write Simply
- Mastering communication: a product manager's superpower
- Connor Murphy on how his team uses a combination of GitLab, Loom, Notion, and Figma to collaborate async between PM, Design, and Engineering (5 min video)

Deeper dive

Please contribute your favorite resources here

Online courses

- LinkedIn Learning: Communication for Product Managers

Books

Please contribute your favorite resources here

- Presentations, prepared and adhoc

Quick reads and videos

Please contribute your favorite resources here

Deeper dive

Please contribute your favorite resources here

Online courses

- LinkedIn Learning: Communicating for Product Managers

Books

Please contribute your favorite resources here

Examples

- Example CAB Presentation

 · Team management

· Stakeholder management

Quick reads and videos

Please contribute your favorite resources here

Deeper dive

- Rosemary King: Stakeholders, let 'em in (20 min video)

Online courses

- Managing Project Stakeholders (LinkedIn Learning course)

Books

Please contribute your favorite resources here

· Cross-functional team management

Quick reads and videos

- HBR: What cross functional teams need to succeed

- HBR: High performing teams need psychological safety

Deeper dive

Please contribute your favorite resources here

Online courses

- LinkedIn Learning: Cross Functional Team Management

Books

- Dare to Lead

- Radical Candor

· Direct team management

New Manager Buddy Program

- For new Group Managers at GitLab, we have an buddy program that matches the new Group Manager with a Senior leader (Director or above) in the Product team that is not in their direct reporting chain. This is an optional program to help new managers understand GitLab management process, find a sounding board to discuss challenging situations in a safe space without judgement, and generally learn management techniques. Although this is targeted to new managers (typically first time managers), it is open to those who are becoming a manager for the first time at GitLab but have been managers elsewhere.

Quick reads and videos

- The New Manager Death Spiral
- How to Improve Your Emotional Intelligence to Become a Better Leader

Deeper dive

- The New Manager Death Spiral (30 min video)

Online courses

- LinkedIn Learning: Building High Performing Teams

Books

- Kim Scott: Radical Candor
- Michael Lopp: Managing Humans
- Julie Zhuo: The Making of a Manager: What to Do When Everyone Looks to You
- First Round Essentials: Management (free ebook download)
- Leadership and influence

Quick reads and videos

- Start with why -- how great leaders inspire action (18 min video)
- Leadership Biz Cafe Podcast

Deeper dive

- LinkedIn Learning: Executive Leadership (1h 19m total)
- LinkedIn Learning: Being a Good Mentor (1 hour total)

Online courses

- LinkedIn Learning Path: Strategic Leadership

Books

- Start with Why: How Great Leaders Inspire Everyone to Take Action
- Trillion Dollar Coach: The Leadership Playbook of Silicon Valley's Bill Campbell
- Extreme Ownership: How U.S. Navy SEALs Lead and Win

Kubernetes

Quick reads and videos

Please contribute your favorite resources here

Deeper dive

- Kubernetes for Product Managers

- Slides
- Video: Part 1
- Video: Part 2
- Video: Part 3

Online courses

Please contribute your favorite resources here

Books

Please contribute your favorite resources here

Product management thought leadership

Blogs, videos and podcasts and more

There is a lot of amazing content and ongoing trends in the world of product development. Subscribing to blogs, video channels and other ongoing content streams is a great way to get inspiration on best practices and product innovation with your team. Here are some recommendations on where to start:

Blogs

- <https://www.svpg.com/articles/>
- <https://www.intercom.com/blog/product-and-design/>
- <https://producthabits.com/blog/>
- <https://www.mindtheproduct.com/>
- <https://cutlefish.substack.com/>

Podcasts

- Mind the Product

- Masters of Scale
- Dollars to Donuts
- Presentable

Newsletters

- Mind the Product Newsletter

Other

- Mind the Product Slack channel
- GitLab team member Viktor Nagy on Twitter
- Product League
- Product School (YouTube Channel)
- Women In Product (YouTube Channel)

Thought leaders and influencers

One of the best ways to stay in the know is to follow people! There are a lot of folks openly sharing their ideas and best practices. We encourage you to follow and exchange ideas with people who inspire you. Here are some recommendations on where to start:

- Jackie Bavaro
- Marty Cagan
- John Cutler
- Ken Norton
- Jeff Patton
- Roman Pichler

How to contribute to the Product L & D Hub

Keeping our Product L & D Hub robust and relevant is a team effort. We encourage to you to contribute as you come across resources that are helpful to you. And if there are resources in the Product L & D Hub that are outdated or you disagree with, we encourage you to bring it to our attention as well.

There are two components to the Product L & D hub:

1. Product Management Learning Hub in Level Up, which is a more modular, personalizable, and trackable portal
1. This page, which serves as the required content library that feeds the Product Management page in Level Up

In order to add content to Product Management Learning Hub, the content must first be added to and exist on this page. Then, the content is added to Level Up.

If there's content you want to add to or remove from this library, simply raise an MR and add any of the product learning evangelists listed below as Reviewer. Tell us in the MR whether you're recommending the resources for just the library or if you'd like to see it added to Level Up as well. Details explaining what you value about the content and how you think it's

helpful should be added to the description of the MR. Please add milestone and labels product operations product handbook and prodops:release to the MR.

Product learning evangelists

Brian Rhea

Farnoosh Seifoddini

Viktor Nagy

SECTION: product/product-management/product-cdf-competencies.md

On this page, you'll find an overview as well as links to helpful resources for evaluating a product manager's performance at GitLab. To better understand a product manager's responsibilities at GitLab, please visit [The Product Manager Role at GitLab](#)

Product Management Career Development Framework

<kbd class="required">Required </kbd>

We track progress through the skills required to be a product manager at all levels via the Product Management Career Development Framework (CDF). The single source of truth for that framework is the table below but you can use this CDF template to track your career development with your manager. We are transitioning the CDF to include the company-wide standard of evaluating performance per the Performance/Growth Matrix. In this model, performance will be considered in categories of Developing, Performing, and Exceeding, alongside evaluation of Developing, Growing, and Exceeding in Growth Output instead of using Growing, Learning, Thriving, and Expert categories of the compa-ratio.

What is the expected outcome of a CDF Review?

CDF reviews should result in actionable improvement focus areas for the product manager. When conducting a CDF review, managers should consider drilling into specific items within the PM's purview to highlight where the team member can focus on improving. PM competencies are also valuable for identifying improvement areas.

We use KPIs by function in the CDF. These KPIs feature a guideline for results that are meant to be suggested indicators for ideal behaviors for Product teammates at GitLab. These are target results and are not meant to be an exhaustive list for Product teammate performance. As a manager and individual contributor, have a dialogue about the right measures of success and define those at the beginning of each performance cycle. Keep the KPIs consistent as you measure them over each CDF review for the best comparative results of growth.

Selecting a Focus Area

In each CDF review, it's recommended to select an improvement area to focus on until the next CDF review. This could be anywhere from 1 to 3 improvement areas that you and your manager select together. Once selected, the teammate and manager check in on those focus areas in each 1:1 reviewing progress, discussing feedback, and adjusting any plans for the quarter to continue to improve. Selecting a focus provides a structure to say "no" to other areas that may not be as timely, critical, or worth the additional focus.

CDF for Individual Contributor Product Managers

Competencies

Product Managers must be able to demonstrate a variety of skills across our CDF. We provide additional career development guidance by listing competencies for each CDF category in order of priority.

We have four core competencies for Product Managers:

1. Product Roadmap & Product Led Growth
2. Sensing Mechanisms
3. Thought Leadership
4. Aligning Teams With HPT

Product Roadmap & Product Led Growth

This competency is about setting and attaining the product direction as defined by the teammate. The teammate is being evaluated on connecting data to product strategy, influencing communication skills internally, plan ambitiously, while effectively practicing iteration, and delivering on the needs of the market.

Example outcomes: MAU Attainment, Dogfooding Implementation %, Use of Growth Experiments

Skills

- Iteration
- Jobs to Be Done
- Lean Product Development
- User Stories
- Backlog Management
- KPIs and Metrics
- Product Strategy
- Growth, Product-led Growth, and Experimentation

Role Expectations

| PM| Senior PM | Principal PM | Senior Principal PM |

| ----- | ----- | ----- |----- |

| Example behaviors\ | Example behaviors\ | Example behaviors\ | Example behaviors\ |

| Adept at setting product direction for assigned product categories on a monthly cadence as informed by the stage direction. Capable of breaking epics into issues and issues into minimal valuable changes (MVCs). Partners with stable counterparts in product group Engineering to

practice iteration and attain monthly active users as set by teammate. Manages product direction and maintains updates to category direction pages. Capable of using data about install base, growing customers, and prospects to prioritize features in a milestone with guidance from product leadership. Capable of using experimentation frameworks with support from growth and product leadership. Monitors monthly active users, error budgets, and other product performance indicators to inform product direction. | Excellent at setting product direction for assigned categories on monthly basis and informs stage direction. Adept at setting quarterly and annual plans. Skilled at breaking epics into issues and issues into minimal valuable changes (MVCs). Works across the stage to practice iteration and attain monthly active users as set by teammate. Proactively manages product direction and maintains updates to category direction pages. Skilled at using data about install base, growing customers, and prospects to prioritize features in a milestone. Skilled at using experimentation frameworks. Proactively and independently monitors monthly active users, error budgets, and other product performance indicators to inform product direction. | Expert at setting product direction for assigned categories on monthly basis and informs section direction. Skilled at setting quarterly and annual plans. Expert at breaking epics into issues and issues into minimal valuable changes (MVCs). Works across the section to practice iteration and attain monthly active users as set by teammate. Coaches others on direction updates and proactively manages product direction updates to category direction pages. Expert at using data about install base, growing customers, and prospects to prioritize features in a milestone. Expert at using experimentation frameworks. Deep understanding of trends in monthly active users, error budgets, and other product performance indicators and how those PIs shape their product direction. Capable of coaching others on PLG methods. | Expert at spotting the need for setting product direction for cross-section and intra-section initiatives. Able to coach others at setting quarterly and annual plans. Mentors, leads by example, and coaches others on breaking epics into issues and issues into minimal valuable changes (MVCs). Works across sections to practice iteration and attain monthly active users as set by teammate. Mentors, leads by example, and coaches others on direction updates. Proactively manages product direction pages. Mentors, leads by example, and coaches others at using data about install base, growing customers, and prospects to prioritize features in a milestone. Mentors, leads by example, and coaches others in using experimentation frameworks. Applies a deep understanding of trends in monthly active users, error budgets, and other product performance indicators and how those PIs shape their product direction. Actively coaches others on PLG methods. |

\ Example behaviors are intended to complement rather than replace the above CDF role expectations. These behaviors illustrate examples of the differences between various levels; however, as the needs and circumstances of each role are unique, not all of these behaviors will be necessary for every role. Additionally, exhibiting all the behaviors of a given role does not guarantee a promotion into that role (see the section below on typical requirements for promotion).

Sensing Mechanisms

This competency is about being able to balance and understand the various inputs of the user, customer, market, and landscape for GitLab. This will include the various levers the teammate will use to inform the product direction and use to shape the execution plans. Each function will have different mixes of sensing mechanisms required for that function, although, in order to effectively satisfy the requirements of the Product Competency all sensing mechanisms should be addressed at some level in the development framework for the teammate's development.

Example outcomes: Uses appropriate methods of Customer Interviewing, Competitive Landscape, Market Research, and new persona research as the basis for Product Direction; Measurement: Direction page updates, DevOps tools updates, Recording of competitive tools walkthroughs, PM Standup Sharing, Opportunity canvases, category mapping

Skills

- User Research
- Customer Interviewing
- Design
- Competitive Analysis
- Relationships with Customers

Role Expectations

| PM| Senior PM | Principal PM | Senior Principal PM |

| ----- | ----- | ----- |----- |

| Example behaviors\ | Example behaviors\ | Example behaviors\ | Example behaviors\ |

| Adept at qualitative customer interviewing. Familiar with prioritization frameworks like RICE to organize opportunity backlogs. Capable of deriving key insights and patterns from customer interviews, and using that input to clarify problem statements. Proficient at story mapping. Proficient at collaborating with Design on prototypes to bring potential solutions to life.

Understands and communicates the business value of epics and issues. Sets success metrics for epics and issues, and tracks metrics post-launch to guide investment in iterative improvements.

Spends up to 20% of time researching & defining category vision & strategy. Evaluates potential and fit of products for acquisition.|

Skilled at qualitative customer interviewing. Excellent at deriving key insights and patterns from customer interviews, and using that input to clarify problem statements. Skilled at story mapping. Excellent at collaborating with Design on prototypes to bring potential solutions to life. Able to ensure activities are consistent with

GitLab's go-to-market and business model. Drives evaluation of build, buy and partner options for solving customer problems. Can identify new market opportunities & author business cases,

as well as forecast the approximate benefits of new features, projected against competition in the space. Spends up to 30% of time researching & defining category vision & strategy|

Expert at qualitative customer interviewing. Skilled at story mapping. Capable of teaching product validation techniques to others. Expert at business case creation. Capable of managing business results across a range of product domains.|

Mentors, leads by example, and coaches in qualitative customer interviewing practices. Highly Proficient at story mapping. Mentors, leads by example, and coaches others in product validation techniques. Expert at business case

creation delivering cross-section, intra-section, and company-wide investment cases for consideration by Product Leadership. Proven execution of business results across multiple product domains.|

\ Example behaviors are intended to complement rather than replace the above CDF role expectations. These behaviors illustrate examples of the differences between various levels; however, as the needs and circumstances of each role are unique, not all of these behaviors will be necessary for every role. Additionally, exhibiting all the behaviors of a given role does not guarantee a promotion into that role (see the section below on typical requirements for promotion).

Thought Leadership

This competency is about the recognition of having technical ownership and being a resource or authority in the domain that the teammate is an expert in. This measure will vary across the Product organization and will be evaluated as an illustration of the Product teammate's capacity to deliver on the domain expertise or represent GitLab to the community.

Example outcomes: Participation in Webinars, Prospect calls, thanks shoutouts by others, engagement in social with community, Analyst recognition and engagement, Creation of artifacts for community and users, Conference participation, and OSS collaboration

Skills

- Product management thought leadership

Role Expectations

| PM| Senior PM | Principal PM | Senior Principal PM |

| ----- | ----- | ----- |----- |

| Example behaviors\ | Example behaviors\ | Example behaviors\ | Example behaviors\ |

| Capable written and verbal communicator internally and externally. Trusted resource for customer calls and meetings. Builds rapport with stakeholders to align around priorities. Drives clarity in area. Takes action to improve behavior based on impact to others. High-level understanding of GitLab product and the relevant product domain(s). High-level understanding of GitLab's architecture and tech stack | Capable of representing GitLab externally at trade shows, customer events, conferences, etc. Appropriately influences & persuade others to a course of action. Solid presentation skills at all levels of the company. Deep familiarity with GitLab's product and the relevant product domain(s). Deep understanding of GitLab's architecture and tech stack. | Recognized as a thought leader internally and externally. Escalates issues cleanly to appropriate levels of authority when decisions or progress are blocked. Excellent presentation skills at all levels of the company. Expert in the relevant product domain(s) and capable of teaching others about the domain. Capable of coaching others on the GitLab product, architecture, and tech stack.| Celebrated as a thought leader internally and externally. Actions on escalations and transparently triages issues to appropriate levels of authority when decisions or progress are blocked. Mentors, leads by example, and coaches others on presentation skills at all levels of the company. Actively teaches others about the owned domain. Actively mentors and coaches others on the GitLab product, architecture, and tech stack.|

\ Example behaviors are intended to complement rather than replace the above CDF role expectations. These behaviors illustrate examples of the differences between various levels; however, as the needs and circumstances of each role are unique, not all of these behaviors will be necessary for every role. Additionally, exhibiting all the behaviors of a given role does not guarantee a promotion into that role (see the section below on typical requirements for promotion).

Aligning Teams with HPT

This competency is about how the teammate facilitates team execution and performance using GitLab values.

Example outcomes: Say/Do, MR Rate, Validation Track Cycle Time and Build Track Cycle Time, OKR

Attainment (70-85% is success, 100% means place for improvement), 360 feedback from counterparts, Values demonstration per our Company Competencies

Skills

- Leadership and influence
- Communicating to inspire, align, and activate
- Cross-functional team management

Role Expectations

| PM| Senior PM | Principal PM | Senior Principal PM |

| ----- | ----- | ----- |----- |

| Example behaviors\ | Example behaviors\ | Example behaviors\ | Example behaviors\ |

| Responsible for the health of working relationships with peers in the stage. Familiar and comfortable with using iteration methodologies and collaborating across the product group. |

Skilled at applying agile development methodologies. Able to elevate performance of the Group through excellent PM outputs. Skilled at applying iteration methodologies and managing with influence while collaborating across the product stage. | Expert at applying agile development methodologies. Able to elevate performance of the peers in the stage. Expert at applying iteration methodologies and managing with influence while collaborating across the product section. | All Principal Behaviors, while proactively building strong cross-section relationships. Able to elevate performance of the peers across the company. Mentors and coaches others on our values including applying iteration methodologies and managing with influence while collaborating across GitLab. |

\ Example behaviors are intended to complement rather than replace the above CDF role expectations. These behaviors illustrate examples of the differences between various levels; however, as the needs and circumstances of each role are unique, not all of these behaviors will be necessary for every role. Additionally, exhibiting all the behaviors of a given role does not guarantee a promotion into that role (see the section below on typical requirements for promotion).

CDF for Individual Contributor Pricing Managers

Below, you'll find the CDF framework and potential discussion topics for Pricing Product Managers.

Product Roadmap & Product Led Growth

This competency is about setting and attaining the product direction as defined by the teammate. The teammate is being evaluated on the ability to plan ambitiously, while effectively practicing iteration, and delivering on the needs of the market. Connecting strategic data-informed skills with influencing communication skills internally. Product is often a cross-functional domain and requires leadership to work across engineering, field, and sales, as well as marketing, to effectively engage the community to grow as well as retain users.

Example outcomes: Pricing, packaging and data analytics strategies aligned with product and business objectives (e.g. user adoption, cost savings, revenue monetization, etc.) and Pricing and packaging aligned to product value drivers (clear articulation of customer's perceived

value and how monetization is aligned with perceived value).

| Pricing Analyst| Senior Pricing Analyst| Principal Pricing Manager |

| ----- |-- |-- |

| Adept at establishing processes and analytical methods to measure success metrics for pricing initiatives. Adept at communicating data insights. Skilled at creating dashboards to inform team members on success metrics. Partners with Product and Pricing Managers to understand project goals and develop a data strategy to support overall initiative. Light-weight project management of data analytic initiatives. Adept at identifying root drivers of problem statements. Skilled in analyzing data to validate connection between root drivers to problem statements. Adept in sourcing data used to validate problem statements. Skilled in using data to clarify problem statements. Adept in using data to refine solution options. | Excellent at establishing processes and analytical methods to measure success metrics for pricing initiatives. Excellent at communicating data insights. Skilled at determining the right dashboards to create that allows team members to review performance of initiatives against success metrics. Partners with Product and Pricing Managers to understand project goals and develop a data strategy to support overall initiative. Advanced project management of data analytic initiatives. Skilled at identifying root drivers of problem statements and analyzing data to validate connection between root drivers to problem statements. Skilled in sourcing and analyzing data to derive key insights to support/drive pricing initiatives. Skilled in using data to clarify problem statements and refine solution options. | Expert at setting success metrics for pricing initiatives and communicating business value of pricing projects. Expert at aligning GitLab's Go-to-market activities and business model with pricing. Expert at identifying monetization drivers and incorporating findings into pricing recommendations. Partners with Product Managers and Sales to understand product vision and sales challenges to build pricing and packaging initiatives. Leads pricing and packaging initiatives. Expert at identifying root drivers of problem statement, forming solution hypotheses, and identifying research needed to validate potential solutions. Skilled at qualitative customer and sales interviewing. Skilled at creating surveys for quantitative analysis. Expert at aggregating data and insights to form a cohesive pricing and packaging recommendation. Capable of teaching pricing validation techniques to others. |

Sensing Mechanisms

This competency is about being able to balance and understand the various inputs of the user, customer, market, and landscape for GitLab. This will include the various levers the teammate will use to inform the product direction and use to shape the execution plans. Each function will have different mixes of sensing mechanisms required for that function, although, in order to effectively satisfy the requirements of the Product Competency all sensing mechanisms should be addressed at some level in the development framework for the teammate's development.

Example outcomes: Uses appropriate methods of customer interviewing, competitive landscape, customer/sales data and market research as basis for Product Direction.

| Pricing Analyst| Senior Pricing Analyst| Principal Pricing Manager |

| ----- |-- |-- |

| Basic understanding of pricing research methodologies. Adept in analyzing data gathered from different pricing surveys to drive insights. Adept at identifying, collecting, and analyzing customer, product usage and sales data to form insights used to drive pricing decisions. | Basic understanding of pricing research methodologies and skilled in analyzing data gathered

from different pricing surveys to drive insights. Skilled at identifying, collecting and analyzing customer, product usage and sales data to form insights used to drive pricing decisions. Skilled at consolidating data and insights to form a comprehensive story. | Expert at incorporating customer options (build, buy and partner) into pricing and packaging recommendations. Be able to clearly articulate the customer's next best alternatives and how it impacts PnP recommendations. Excellent in the understanding of pricing research methodologies and being able to identify appropriate method(s) to be used for a given situation: basic survey questions on interests/needs, Van Westdorp, Gabor-Granger, Max-Diff, Conjoint, etc.]

Thought Leadership

This competency is about the recognition of having technical ownership and being a resource or authority in the domain that the teammate is an expert in. This measure will vary across the Product organization and will be evaluated as an illustration of the Product teammate's capacity to deliver on the domain expertise or represent GitLab to the community.

Example outcomes: Participation in Webinars, Prospect calls, thanks shoutouts by others, engagement in social with community.

| Pricing Analyst| Senior Pricing Analyst| Principal Pricing Manager |

| ----- |-- |-- |

| Adept at identifying data needs in order to support/drive pricing initiatives. Adept at driving improvements to data collection and analysis methods when data gaps are identified. Adept at driving data infrastructure improvements when required. Trusted resource for internal teams to provide pricing insights based on data. | Skilled at identifying data needs in order to support/drive pricing initiatives. Skilled at identifying data gaps and developing the data infrastructure to provide the required insights. Trusted resource for internal teams to provide pricing insights based on data. | Recognized as a thought leader internally and externally. Escalates issues cleanly to appropriate levels of authority when decisions or progress are blocked. Excellent presentation skills at all levels of the company. Expert in the relevant product domain(s). Capable of coaching others on the pricing frameworks, discount methodologies, and sales operations based on in-depth knowledge of the relevant product domain's value proposition. |

Aligning Teams with Values

This competency is about the teammate facilitates the team execution and performance using GitLab values.

Example outcomes: Say/Do, MR Rate, Validation Track Cycle Time and Build Track Cycle Time, OKR Attainment (70-85% is success, 100% means place for improvement), 360 feedback from counterparts, Values demonstration per our Company Competencies

| Pricing Analyst| Senior Pricing Analyst| Principal Pricing Manager |

| ----- |-- |-- |

| Responsible for the health of working relationships with peers in the stage. Familiar and comfortable with using iteration methodologies and collaborating across the product group. | Skilled at applying agile development methodologies. Able to elevate performance of the Group through excellent PM outputs. Skilled at applying iteration methodologies and managing with influence while collaborating across the product stage. | Expert at applying agile development

methodologies. Able to elevate performance of the peers in the stage. Expert at applying iteration methodologies and managing with influence while collaboration across the product section. |

CDF for Product Leadership

The below table outlines the Career Development Framework used for Product Leaders.

Typical scope and reporting structure is documented in the Product Management Leadership job family.

Competencies

All Managers and above in the Product function are considered product leaders. The Product Leader competencies describes important leadership concepts specific to the product management team. See also our page on general GitLab leadership guidance.

Product Roadmap & Product Led Growth

This competency is about setting and attaining the product direction as defined by the teammate. The teammate is being evaluated on connecting data to product strategy, influencing communication skills internally, plan ambitiously, while effectively practicing iteration, and delivering on the needs of the market.

Example outcomes: MAU growth/retention, ARR Influence, Cross-company alignment for product roadmap

Responsibilities

Responsibilities outlined in the Group Manager of Product Job Family page.

Group Manager

- Coaching of team members on validation track skills
- Strategic research
- Driving cross-group connections in service of a single-app experience
- Adoption Funnel across product groups
- Partnership with GTM via Use Case assignment

Role Expectations

Group Manager	Director	Senior Director	VP

| Leads strategic research that spans and extends beyond product scope. Plans on an annual and quarterly product vision cadence. Spots opportunities for cross-group, cross-stage, or cross-section collaboration and learning. Demonstrates and coaches business skills to others. Regularly maintains high-level Direction and ensures Direction alignment across the scope. Develops a deep understanding of the adoption funnel across groups and stages. | Executes research and customer interviewing across the section as a GitLab representative. Plans on a 3-year to annual product vision cycle. Creates opportunities for cross-stage and cross-section

collaboration. Active coach for business skills across the product organization, including feedback on opportunity canvases, product proposals, and MVCs. | Represents GitLab product in strategic customer calls, Customer Advisory Board Sessions, and prospects to inform 5-year+ product vision and strategy. Contributes to annual themes, yearlies, and OKRs to align section with broader company strategy. Provides coaching to direct reports on crafting vision in respective areas. | |

Sensing Mechanisms

This competency is about being able to balance and understand the various inputs of the user, customer, market, and landscape for GitLab. This will include the various levers the teammate will use to inform the product direction and use to shape the execution plans. Each function will have different mixes of sensing mechanisms required for that function, although, in order to effectively satisfy the requirements of the Product Competency all sensing mechanisms should be addressed at some level in the development framework for the teammate's development.

Example outcomes: Continuous evaluation of competitive landscape, active participation and execution of merger and acquisition, drives GTM alignment on key product deliveries, and engages SUS/PNPS for user interviews.

Responsibilities

Responsibilities outlined in the Group Manager of Product Job Family page.

Group Manager

- Coaching of team members on business skills
- Acquisitions
- Deep understanding, synthesis, and communication of competitive landscape and emergent solutions
- Business Cases for new investment
- Direction updates

Role Expectations

Group Manager	Director	Senior Director	VP

| Partners with GTM on assigned Use Cases. Establishes a deep understanding of competitive and emergent solutions. Leads acquisition and new investment business case creation. Capable of managing business results across a range of product domains. | Collaborates with pricing team to define pricing and packaging strategy for a section. Champions acquisition opportunities including business case creation. Proactively manages adoption funnels and performance indicators across stages. Identifies GTM opportunities and engages with leaders to capitalize on them for the section. | Contributes to pricing discussions across the portfolio and makes recommendations on strategy. Identifies and champions acquisition opportunities and provides coaching to direct reports on effective positioning and business case creation. Leads cross-section dialogue on product performance indicators and helps identify opportunities for cross-section partnership. Works with GTM and Customer success leadership to deliver on portfolio priorities. | |

Thought Leadership

This competency is about the recognition of having technical ownership and being a resource or authority in the domain that the teammate is an expert in. This measure will vary across the Product organization and will be evaluated as an illustration of the Product teammate's capacity to deliver on the domain expertise or represent GitLab to the community.

Example outcomes: Represent GitLab externally in industry talks, podcasts, or conferences. Creates content for product vision. Coaches teammates on employing effective thought leadership mechanisms. Actively engages analysts for generating market priorities.

Responsibilities

Responsibilities outlined in the Group Manager of Product Job Family page.

Group Manager

- Presenting broader GitLab Roadmap
- Represent GitLab at Conferences

Role Expectations

Group Manager	Director	Senior Director	VP

| Consistently communicates a product vision and creates a bias towards action in their communication. Recognized as a thought leader internally and externally. Excellent presentation skills at all levels of the company. Spots murkiness and escalates issues cleanly to appropriate levels of authority when decisions or progress are blocked. Able to represent GitLab Section Direction deeply and company-wide roadmap broadly. | Establishes a compelling team purpose that is aligned with the overall organizational vision. Inspires a broader team to achieve results. Identifies disconnects to vision and takes appropriate action. | Actively engages the market, analysts, and other software leaders in the industry to represent GitLab and our product management philosophy. Active participant in industry conferences. Engages analysts in portfolio discussions. | |

Aligning Teams with Values

This competency is about how the teammate facilitates team execution and performance using GitLab values.

Example outcomes: Lives CREDIT values. Coaches others on CREDIT Values. OKR execution and completion by the team. Stage and Section Say/Do ratios or MR rates are attaining targets.

Responsibilities

Responsibilities outlined in the Group Manager of Product Job Family page.

Group Manager

- Partnership with Design leadership

- High-performing team
- Enabling direct reports to be more efficient
- Shared understanding of team goals and targets
- Hiring and at managing underperformance.
- Caring personally for team members.
- Candid real-time feedback.

Note Aligning Teams with Values includes People Management Skills

Role Expectations

Group Manager	Director	Senior Director	VP

| Develops strong partnership with Cross-functional counterparts leadership in Stage. Ensures effectiveness of R&D investment. Partners with Engineering Leadership to ensure product groups attain cross-functional performance indicators and that R&D resources are being effectively allocated. Establishes and executes a portfolio management strategy across stages in sections. Aligns team with larger Stage vision and goals. Translates and aligns strategy in a meaningful way for the team, building a shared understanding of team goals and targets. Uses situational leadership techniques to provide the appropriate level of guidance and latitude to team members. Proactively identifies and fills talent gaps. Adept at caring personally for team members. Provides candid real-time feedback. | Enables strong partnership with UX Research and Product Design to ensure our R&D investment is effective across stages and the section. Responsible for the health of working relationships with fellow Engineering Directors. Evaluates and optimizes product hierarchy to ensure we are organized to efficiently deliver on our R&D investments. Coaches groups to create a high-performance organization that meets performance indicators across functions. Establishes and executes portfolio management strategy across scope with peer Directors. Aligns team with scope's larger vision and goals. Provides appropriate level of guidance and latitude to managers and individuals. Experienced at hiring and at managing underperformance. Excellent at caring personally for team members. Provides candid real-time feedback. | Enables strong partnership with UX Research and Product Design to ensure our R&D investment is effective across the portfolio. Responsible for the health of working relationships with Engineering functions and product organization. Provides coaching on the effective use of R&D investments. Coaches product team to create a high-performance organization that meets performance indicators across functions. Coaches direct reports on portfolio management strategy. Aligns product team with scope's larger vision and goals. Provides appropriate level of guidance and latitude to managers and individuals. Expert at hiring and at managing underperformance. Excellent at caring personally for team members. Provides candid real-time feedback. | |

Evaluating Product Manager's potential

When evaluating a product manager's potential, in addition to the generic information outlined, we also want to evaluate potential based on the unique and outsized impact PMs can have. We acknowledge that the evaluation will remain more qualitative than quantitative, but rather than shy away from making an evaluation, we will lean in using the information below.

We can think about the Product Manager's potential primarily on two axis: value creation and leadership.

Value Creation

Product managers are in the business of creating value, measurable by Product KPIs. They prioritize the most important thing to unlock the most value at the intersection of the business and the user or buyer. At GitLab, Product Managers are often the business owner of their segment and outputs are not just in the delivery of features to production, rather can include go-to-market, sales enablement, partner/channel/alliances relationships, and understanding revenue impact of the product offering.

We expect product managers to create value across the business by excelling at execution in at least the following levels. When thinking of a PM's potentials, consider their capacity to expand their influence beyond their current level.

Level	Value created at..
PM	features and categories
Senior PM	features, categories and stage
Principal PM	features, categories, stage, and cross-stage
GPM	stage and cross-stage
Director	cross-stage, cross-department
VP and up	company-wide or new business/industry

Leadership

As product managers grow in experience and seniority, they are tasked with shaping alignment, producing results, and leading with increasing responsibilities. Understanding how to set the tone with vision and strategy, and knowing how to control output in a system comprised of people, culture, technology, and process is how product managers lead.

We expect product managers to be a leader at the following levels. When evaluating potential, consider the PM's capacity to be a leader with more scope.

Level	Leadership level
PM	product group
Senior PM/Principal PM	product group, stage, and cross-group alignment
GPM/Director	multiple groups and stages
Senior Director	cross-department
VP	company-wide

A framework for evaluating potential

It can be challenging objectively evaluating product managers for categorization of Low, Medium and High potential as suggested in the Performance/Potential Matrix. Consider using the following framework to rank a PM's potential. Assign a ranking, 1 (Low) - 5 (High) to each attribute below. Add up the rankings for a total score. A score between 5-11 is low potential, 12-18 is medium potential, 19-25 is high potential.

Attribute	Reasoning
-----	-----

Self-motivation and drive	The intrinsic drive enables PMs to learn, be passionate, and ultimately be effective.
Influence	High potential PMs build rapport with their team, which supports accomplishing results.
Resourcefulness	PMs should seek to learn and grow. What they learn is ultimately meaningful if the learning can be applied.
Ambitious	High potential PMs stretch themselves and make themselves available to new responsibility.
Self-awareness	A large part of leadership is knowing where you are not strong and building relationships to fill in the gaps.

Make evaluating potential actionable

Product managers are typically driven and high performing individuals, and we often overestimate our own abilities relative to others. Seeing even a medium potential may be disappointing to many PMs. It should be made clear that a perceived lower than desired potential does not mean the PM is not valued and not performing to expectation. Managers should use a CDF Review to discuss the scoring of the potential. The outcome should be to identify opportunities for the PM to grow and areas for the manager to mentor and coach the PM.

Supporting a Product Manager's Career

We want Product Managers to succeed in their careers at GitLab and beyond. Product Managers are encouraged to fill out and talk to their managers about their longer-term career goals either as part of their CDF reviews or as a separate career coaching discussion. To help facilitate, track and make time for overall career growth, Product Managers can fill out this specific template for career coaching conversations in the main CDF template (internal only). Having all career development and progression in one document will help both Product Managers and their Managers keep track of progress.

Typical Requirements for Promotions

Promotions follow the standard promotion process and adhere to the promotion philosophy. When reviewing a proposed promotion, we consider: 1) readiness of the individual, and 2) business justification/opportunity. Team members should already be demonstrating some of the next level job frameworks levels before promotion and a promotion document should be completed. For promotions to take effect, the budget needs to be available and approved. If there is not a business need substantial enough to justify a promotion opportunity, it is possible that otherwise qualified individuals may not be able to be promoted until an opportunity becomes available.

Unless there is a justifiable exception, the requirements below are also typically required to be met for individual contributor promotions within the Product department:

Levels	PM	Senior PM	Principal PM	Senior Principal PM	
-----	-----	-----	-----	-----	
Typical Business Need	A Group requires PM support and the manager has bandwidth to support a PM. A Group requires PM support including deeper strategic direction and cross-group coordination within the Stage. A Stage requires extensive PM support, strategic leadership, and cross-stage coordination within the Section. The company requires broad PM				

support, strategic leadership, and cross-section coordination. |
| Typical Reporting Structure | Reports to a Group Manager or Director | Reports to a Group Manager or Director | Reports to a Group Manager, Director, or Senior Director | Reports to a Senior Director, or VP |

Contributing to our PM Competencies and CDF Criteria

Every GitLab team member is encouraged to contribute to the list of prioritized Product Manager competencies and CDF criteria, as well as the content for each competency via merge requests to this page.

To contribute to the competencies, open an issue in the Product project using the Product Competencies template. The steps in the issue will guide you through getting a future competency merged into this page.

SECTION: product/product-management/product-manager-buddy-tasks.md

1. [] - Book a 1:1 with the new Product Manager for day 1
1. [] - Schedule a reminder to check in on their onboarding issue, how are they doing, how can you help, etc. that is recurring for their first 6 weeks.
1. [] - Suggest handbook pages they may find useful
 - Pages from the onboarding buddy handbook page
 - Product Specific Pages
 - Validation Track
 - Product Development Timeline
 - Getting Access to Data as a PM
 - Managing your Product Direction
 - How to work as a PM
 - Pricing / tier related
 - <<https://handbook.gitlab.com/handbook/company/pricing/three-tiers>>
 - Buyer Personas
 - Product Categories page to find who is the DRI for a category
 - Features by tier and group
 - Analytics Direction Page
 - Helpful for research
 - How/When to start a research project
 - How to recruit for a UX Project
 - Dovetail
 - Getting access to Dovetail
 - GitLab Dovetail projects
 - Documenting insights in Dovetail
1. [] - Remind them to introduce themselves
 - In newteammembers
 - In product
 - You will get introduced in the next product meeting and asked where did you work before GL, why did you join, where are you located, what do you do for fun outside of work.
 - You may share with them how you introduced yourself.
1. [] - Encourage them to organize a group call with the other new hires

1. [] - Intro to slack

- Channels to be aware of
 - Product related - product, uxresearch, competition, analyst-relations, analytics, analytics-social, etc.
 - Fun - random, allcaps, loc channels and there are others, just search for things you might find fun and interesting.

- Tips/Tricks

- Update your profile in Slack, especially your working hours and location
- Make use of starred channels, what's most important to you.
- Add keywords to get alerted on for your product area, competitors, etc.

1. [] - Add a reminder for once a week to ask what they couldn't get an answer on this week, how to get them unstuck for the first 6 weeks.

1. [] - Ask them after a few days if they got their team page MR merged.

1. [] - Tips / Tricks for sensing mechanisms

- There is a good breakdown of sensing mechanism in the handbook. Some other things I have found useful are;

- Go other places customers/user are like the GitLab forum and Discord, Reddit and HackerNews are just a few.

- Issues - It is good practice to review new issues assigned to your group that may get missed by the weekly triage issues. There can be good conversation to be had discussing problems/desired outcomes with users within a day or two of them creating an issue.

- Slack - Adding keywords to your Slack alerts like your category name, competitor names, etc. is a good way to stay on top of issues bubbling up, potential customers, etc. in channels you are joined.

- Analyst Reports - You can inquire about access to reports from analysts in the analyst-relations channel.

1. [] - The flow of a milestone

- Rough timeline of the flow
- Planning

- Each milestone there is a kickoff issue created and assigned to PMs. Link your planning issue in that and once recorded your kickoff call.

- Kickoff call

- Hold a call with your Designer talking about the issues the team will work on that milestone with preference to issues that are ~direction AND ~Deliverable.

- During the milestone

- Keep an eye on your TODOs if you use them for pings/questions from your development team or customers/users asking about progress on issues to keep them moving.

- Release posts

- Important deadlines are having them in review by Technical Writing and PMM two weeks prior to the release and merged 7 days prior to the release.

- Moving issues that do not finish in the milestone

- This is an

[<https://handbook.gitlab.com/handbook/engineering/infrastructure/engineering-productivity/triage-operations/milestone-reschedule>] to move issues that do not finish in a milestone but it's good to review issues that were not closed in a milestone as it does not move confidential issues.

- Retrospectives

- Direction updates

- There is no wrong time to update your direction pages when something has changed. The cadence of a release is a great time to schedule it to ensure it is happening regularly though.

- Performance Indicators / OKRs
 - After the close of a milestone it is a good time to regularly check in on your Performance Indicators and OKRs for the quarter.

SECTION: product/product-management/product-manager-role.md

On this page, you'll find an overview as well as links to helpful resources for working as a product manager at GitLab. To better understand how we evaluate a product manager's work at GitLab, please visit Product Management CDF and Competencies

{{% include "includes/product-handbook-links.md" %}}

Product Organizational Structure

The GitLab Product team includes team members at various levels of Product Management job titles and Product Management - Leadership job titles. They map across our organizational levels with scope at various points in our product hierarchy outlined in the table below.

The product org abides by GitLab's layer structure. Sometimes, there can be instances where peers across layers don't have the same title.

Level	Job Titles	Hierarchy	Scopes
IC	Product Manager, Senior PM, Principal PM	Group, Stage	Manager
	Group Manager Product, Director of Product	Collection of Groups, Stage, Section	Director
	Director of Product, Senior Director of Product	Section, Collection of Sections	
	Senior Leader	VP	All Sections (though depending on scope and business need, can also cover less)
	Executive	Chief Product Officer	Entire Function

Working as a PM at GitLab

Responsibilities

Your job as a PM is outlined in Product Manager Responsibilities

Getting started as a PM at GitLab

The first thing to do is to familiarize yourself with the following handbook pages

- Product Principles
- Product Processes
- Product Manager Responsibilities
- Product Manager Career Development Framework
- Product Development Flow

Product Development Timeline

Product Management Learning & Development

GitLab Values

As a GitLab Product Manager, your product scope is huge! It may seem daunting at first, but GitLab is constantly iterating on our processes and organization so that you can be successful. Since everything is in draft, please make a proposal to improve things.

As a PM you may be extremely busy if you try to do everything that people ask you to do. This is not our expectation for the role.

We do expect you to prioritize expertly and be a manager of one. And remember what your core responsibilities are! If you find yourself drowning in To-Dos, take a step back, prioritize, push-back, and focus your energy on the most important things.

Some helpful reminders:

As a PM, you're the person that has to kick-off new initiatives. You're not responsible for shipping something on time, but you are responsible for taking action and setting the direction. Be active everywhere, over-communicate, and sell the things you think are important to the rest of the team and community.

As a PM, you need to set the bar for engineering. That is, to push engineering and the rest of the company. You almost want engineering to complain about the pace that product is setting. Our default instinct will be to slow down, but we can't give in to that.

As a PM you don't own the product; ask other people for feedback and give team members and the community the space to suggest and create things without your direct intervention. It's your job to make sure things are decided and planned, not come up with every idea or change.

Where should you look when you need help?

The first thing you should do is read this page carefully and the pages linked from this page. Most answers can also be found in the handbook. If you can't find the answer, please add a proposal!

You can ask questions related to Product in the product Slack channel.

General questions should be asked in questions.

Specific Git related questions should be asked in git-help.

If you have problems with a MR, ask in mr-buddies.

HR questions should be asked in HelpLab.

Anything Release Post related can be found in the Release Post handbook and release-post

Job Requirements

The job requirements and expectations for Product Managers, Sr. Product Managers, and Principal Product Managers, Group Manager, Product Management Director of Product and VP of Product are outlined in our job families pages.

As product managers progress in their product career, we encourage our product managers to take on new challenges by moving to new product areas. Alternatively, IC PMs are encouraged to apply

for roles in the management track and vice versa.

The progression of responsibilities allocation between tactical, operational and strategic in product roles is well illustrated by this chart.

Source File. Note - Thanks to Melissa Perri for the inspiration

Important dates PMs should keep in mind

4th of the Month:

Draft of the issues that will be included in the next release.
Start capacity and technical discussions with engineering/UX.

12th of the Month:

Release scope is finalized. In-scope issues marked with milestone
Kickoff document is updated with relevant items to be included.

15th of the Month:

Group Kickoffs calls recorded and uploaded by the end of the day.

Also see Product Development Timeline.

Scope of responsibilities

The product team is responsible for iteration on most of GitLab's products and projects:

GitLab CE and EE
GitLab.com
about.gitlab.com
customers.gitlab.com
version.gitlab.com

This includes the entire stack and all its facets. The product team needs to weigh and prioritize not only bugs, features, regressions, and performance, but also architectural changes and other aspects required for ensuring GitLab's excellence. Product managers are the DRIs for overall work prioritization but work collaboratively with their EM, UX, and QEM stable counterparts to ensure the right priorities from each work type are considered as each has a different DRI.

Learning and Development for Product Management

We have a library dedicated to collecting and highlighting the best resources to support the growth and success of product managers in doing their job at GitLab as well as beyond, to

achieve their long term career goals. We encourage product managers to work with their managers to identify areas for improvement, and leverage the learning and development for product management resources accordingly.

Product Manager Onboarding

Product Manager onboarding consists of 2 related issue templates.

GitLab People Connect Onboarding Issue is generated by People Connect at around 4 business days prior to the start date of the new hire. More details can be found on the GitLab Onboarding Processes. The issue will be assigned to the hiring manager, who will after performing their tasks, assign it to the new product manager hire. There is a product specific section in this issue that includes clerical product tasks, i.e. schedule introductory calls with your team, that need to be completed within the first 4 weeks. The hiring manager can ping the assigned People Connect Team member in the issue or reach out for help in HelpLab. The product manager should not spend more than 4 weeks on this general onboarding and consult with their manager to prioritize the items in the template as needed to manage the time commitment.

Additionally, the product team has the First 100 days template.

The hiring manager will prep/personalize the First 100 days template. We encourage these issues to default to public per our values but they may be marked confidential if there is any sensitive or personal data per the manager's discretion. The First 100 days issue should be open for the new product manager on their start date. It isn't expected that they get started on this issue, but it is intended to give them a general idea of what is coming. Generally, the First 100 days issue kicks off around the start of the new milestone, around 2-4 weeks after the product manager's start data. This timing is intended to help to allow enough time for tactical/general onboarding, before the new product manager starts to figure out what their first 100 days in "office" looks like more strategically. However, the timing/content of the first 100 days is ultimately up to the product manager and their manager to agree upon.

The new hire should also participate in defining and adding to the goals of the First 100 days template. It is recommended that the manager leverage this goal-oriented onboarding issue for the new product managers first CDF review, to effectively align teammates in supporting the PM as they settle into their role at GitLab. Take a look at these first 100 days onboarding issues as examples: 3291 and 2809.

We use two templates, so the Product Manager can focus on GitLab onboarding for the first month with more urgent, tactical tasks. As the new Product Manager becomes more familiar with GitLab they can transition to more strategic and less time-sensitive onboarding tasks in their first 3 months at GitLab.

Onboarding issues can be tracked in the Product Onboarding Issue Board.

Product Manager Onboarding Buddy

As part of onboarding a new hire will be given an Onboarding Buddy. As a Product Manager onboarding buddy there are many processes and resources to share with the new hire. A list of tasks and resources specific to Product Managers can be found [here](#)

Interviewing Product Management Candidates

A unique and important step in the interview process for Product Management candidates is our Deep Dive Interview. The goal of this interview is to understand the candidate's ability to communicate a long term vision as well as a short term MVC, both verbally during the interview itself, and written via two follow up issues. Once the issues are ready for you to read, it is an opportunity to provide feedback and see how the candidate responds to that feedback.

You can find more information and instructions on the Deep Dive interview [here](#)(internal only). For information on our hiring process, head over to our hiring handbook pages. |

Taking Time Off

<figure class="videocontainer">
 <iframe src="https://www.youtube.com/embed/AkNcYjWrvDU" frameborder="0"
allowfullscreen="true"> </iframe>
</figure>

Team members are strongly recommended to take two weeks of consecutive time off a year. Extended leave longer than the no ask, must tell GitLab paid time off is common, especially for parental leave. Leaving for a longer period of time can be daunting, but it is critical to ensure your rest ethic meets your work ethic and also to ensure we don't have single points of failure in the company. Here are a few suggestions for product managers to help plan for this time.

On a high level, these are the two most important things to do:

1. Communicate your time off
1. Create a PM coverage issue (details below)

Creating a PM coverage issue

You can use this issue template to define handshake responsibilities. For extended leave, it is important to find one or more Directly Responsible Individuals (DRIs) that will be able to make product decisions while you are away. This may be your manager, another PM, or maybe the engineering manager for your team. The coverage issue should contain all the necessary information for the DRIs to make good decisions in your absence, so please make sure to include as much detail as needed.

In addition to creating the issue, it may be useful to have a specific handover meeting to ensure that everyone is on the same page before you leave.

It is recommended to work with your manager and Quad members when considering cross-functional teammate capacity for a coverage task assignment. For example, while it's optimal for PM, EM, and PDs to assist in covering for each other given their shared knowledge of their product area including customers and users, UX teammates may or may not have the bandwidth or expertise to take on covering PM specific responsibilities. Alternatively, it may be better for the manager of the PM or another PM in the same stage to aid in coverage. Plan to have the necessary conversations across teams and managers.

Returning from Time Off

Returning from time off can be overwhelming and daunting. You should work with your DRIs to understand what has changed during your absence and what the current priorities are. Also, communicate transparently that your response time may be slower because you are catching up. Here are some additional tips on how to return back to work after time off.

Product Shadowing with Engineering

The Product Shadowing program is loosely based on the CEO Shadow program and is designed to facilitate greater understanding between Product Managers and Engineers within a stage. The program was trialed with success in the Plan stage.

A Product Manager can host an Engineer within their stage to shadow them over two working days, or the equivalent split over multiple days to maximize experience with different functions of the role.

To propose a shadow, please create an issue in the stage issue track